

Chapter IIII

The Bandit King

Heavy stone scrapes against granite tiles, as the door to the war room closes.

Thea stands in front of them, glaring at the spots where *they* were all sitting. “Idiots”, she mutters. Those Lords are old-fashioned. They hold onto their obsolescent values, as though they are defensive walls, protecting them from a terrible fate. That’s what the castle walls are for. Stubborn, cultural based laws are a leash.

With a deep breath, Thea expels the frustration. Anger never solves problems. She knows this, so she does not let her darker impulses get the better of her. Thea turns, her slow exhale coming out as a short squeal of shock.

Otto leans against the opposite wall, watching her.

“What are you doing?” Thea asks, a bit more stern than intended.

“Hoping to accompany, Her Grace, on a walk” he replies, flashing a scoundrels smirk.

“I thought you were going to the battlements, what will happen if they decide they want you back.” She jests. Otto chuckles at that. With a beckoning wave he turns to the courtyard opening.

The two walk out into the cold air. The open roof allows the small moon, Vex, to shine a beautiful blue over the gardens. White and red tiles weave around dead and frozen flowerbeds. The courtyard is empty and peaceful.

“I do like this garden,” Otto voices, “It’s the one part of this city I actually enjoy.”

“Such a small, quiet place seems far from your happy place” Thea remarks, stopping to lean over the walkway railing and gaze out at the city. “You’re not impressed by Hollow Tor?”

She always has been. The city is ancient and fascinating. A mountain that has been carved into a fortified society. Large portions of the city are under the cover of rock, which is speckled by the shimmering lights of reflective minerals.

“We used to call it The Mud Castle,” he recalls flatly, “Of course, that was before I had actually seen it.”

Otto joins Thea, but doesn't face the city below. Instead he watches the garden corpses sway with the breeze.

"It was impressive, sure. Everyone is always so impressed when they see the mountain broken by man. But, it wasn't long before I began to wonder how beautiful the mountain was before it was defiled." Otto catches a twisting leaf, blown by the wind. He looks to be deep in contemplation.

Thea stares at him, incredibly confused. She knows the man has a certain wit. To have accomplished what he has, one must be at least a little clever. But he talks like a philosopher, not a brutish battle commander.

"Tiera built this city." She corrects.

Otto raises an eyebrow.

"It was Gods that built Hollow Tor, not men. Ra'Kax, carved the mountain. Then his sister built the city. Destruction and Creation, weaved together."

Otto smiles again.

"You're right, of course." Otto asserts, performatively throwing up his hands. "Unlike Your Grace, I did not have the luxury of a structured education. Only tall tails told by drunk men."

Smile fading, he returns to his quiet admiration of the dead flowers.

Thea sees the avoidance, but chooses not to pry. This man uses humor and false ignorance to disguise his true intellectual ability. It is as much a tactic as it is a defense mechanism, she thinks.

Uncomfortable with the silence, Thea decides to end this interaction. After the failed test, she should find the Grey Lady to arrange her next lessons. She cringes at the prospect. But as she turns from the railing, Otto raises his hand to block her path.

Thea gives him a questioning look. He scans around the dark outskirts of the courtyard, before speaking.

"So tell me, what is your plan, Princess?" he asks.

Thea is taken aback by the question, "What do you mean?"

“You’re not going to go back to study with the Grey Ladies are you?” Otto’s voice has no tone of playfulness. His demeanor has become stoic and assertive. He holds a piercing gaze into Thea’s eyes.

“It’s what father thinks is best.” It is all she can think to say.

Otto scoffs. “And what do you think is best, Princess?” he implores, “Your talents are wasted with those old hags.” He takes a few steps into the courtyard. Reaching down he grabs a handful of snow and rubs it between his fingers. “Your father is losing this war Thea” he says with somber lament, “Nothing is going to change unless we start making our own decisions”

Thea’s eyes widen as she processes his words. “Our own decisions?” She questions suspiciously. “What is that supposed to mean?”

Otto shifts uncomfortably but does not answer. Thea takes a step back, disgusted and angered. “You’re leaving aren’t you?” She sneers.

“Yes, I am,” Otto responds bluntly. He fixes his brown eyes on her enraged ones with stubborn resolve. “My voice is silent here. My army is miles away. And my home even further still. If the lethargic lords cannot put aside their facades of honour, and accept my help, then I shall offer it no longer.”

The words should make Thea angry, but instead they fill her with dread. Otto’s soldiers not only make up a sizable portion of the remaining army, but they are also especially adept at surviving this southern terrain. True natives of this land.

“You’d leave us to die.” Her voice twitches with mortal fear. Otto’s face contorts.

“I have to think about *my* people.” he says softly.

“And what is stopping me from telling my father?” Thea asks, desperation taking over. “You’re going to abandon us. Tuck tail and run. Cower in the forest, while the Vienna’s relieve us of our heads. Well then tell me, Lord Sparrow, is that the sort of *King* you are?”

His face hardens, and in an instant he is nose to nose with Thea. She feels his measured breaths against her frozen cheeks. There is a fire in those dark eyes of his, but when he speaks it is with a calm and steady tone. “I understand that you are upset. But

know that naming someone a coward outside these walls will not end well for you. Us Jakan our proud people.”

“Back away, Lord Sparrow.” Thea replies forcefully, her fists clenched in rage and fear.

With a sharp exhale of annoyance he does. Turning away from Thea to look out at Hollow Tor with dismissive glare.

“I am not going to run like you think, Thea,” he continues, “I have been ordered to take my people to the northern borders, secure outskirt villages, and patrol the Deep Lands. They want my people to act as a meat shield. A barrier of blood between the monsters that lurk beyond and their precious dirt hole of a city.”

He whips around to stare intently at Thea, “I will not stand by and watch as those who believe in me are sent to the grinder. Jaka is their home, not their battleground, not their grave.

“The true cowards are the ones in that war room. They refuse to take risks, fearing that more mistakes will be their end. I intend to take the risk for them.”

Thea’s fear and outrage is washed away by dread. A horrible realisation begins to form in her mind as she takes in the determined will of this man. Instinctively she analyses his body language, searching for truth beyond the exterior. She watches his boot tap repeatedly against the icy stone. Observes his thumb rubbing over the knuckles of his left hand. And notices the muscles across his cheekbones tense.

He is like a coiled python. Wound by restrained bloodlust. Ready to strike.

“You’re going to Nuarivera.” She utters in disbelief.

Otto does not answer. He just continues to stare at her. Eventually he shrugs, and adopts a childish smile once more.

“It is impossible to slip anything past you.” He chuckles.

“You’re insane.” Thea mutters, her wide eyes darting across him. He is too calm, too relaxed. “You will die. As tough as your army may be. As clever as you think you are. You are no match for them. It’s doubtful you would even make it out of the Deep Lands. By Gods... what are you thinking?”

Otto raises a gentle hand.

“I will not be marching north to the sound of warhorns, while swinging my banner above my head. Only a fool like Keper would be so gaudy.”

“So, what then?” Thea interjects. “Say you can sneak in, there will be thousands of soldiers between you and Hylestus. Frequent patrols. Riders scouting from the sky.”

Frustration returns as she thinks of the compounding futility of this decision. “You think your people will die if they’re stationed along our border. But you will be ensuring their death if you lead them north.”

Otto sighs deeply. He grabs another handful of snow, letting like flakes fall between his fingers.

“I already told you. I’m not going to send my people to the grinder. They will stay here.”

“You’re going alone?” Thea quavers. For some reason, that thought scares her more.

Otto nods.

“You want to tell your pa? Go ahead, tell him.” He remarks indifferently, “I doubt he would do much to stop me. But, something tells me that you won’t mention my plan to him.”

“What gives you that idea?” Thea splutters in bewilderment.

Otto steps casually towards her. Again, he leans in close to Thea face, and speaks softly, “Because despite how proper and noble you pretend to be, you have a temperament closer to mine than any of your regular company. It won’t be long before you too decide to leave this cage.”

With that he walks away through the garden, calling back one last thing before he is lost in shadows. “*One must walk their own path in life, and smite any who get in the way.* A mad man once told me that.”

Thea watches him disappear, unable to make sense of the storm of emotions within her. She breathes deep, to expel the fog. But her mind remains clouded. Her eyes flick up to the west tower, where a single window glows with candle light.

“*Those who are blind believe me mad.*” She mutters, before heading back inside.